

Personal Statement Brainstorm

FOR THE STUDENT

Gets a real essay out of you without staring at a blank document. None of these questions is the essay — one of the answers will be.

When: Summer before senior year

Ten minutes, no editing

Write badly on purpose. You cannot revise a blank page.

A time I was genuinely wrong about something

Something I do that nobody assigned me

A thing my family does that I assumed everyone did

The hardest thing I have had to figure out on my own

Something small I notice that other people walk past

A moment I surprised myself

Go deeper on one

Pick the answer above you would most want to explain to a stranger.

What actually happened — just the facts, in order

What I was thinking at the time

What I think about it now

What this shows about how I handle things

The test

- ☐ Could only I have written this? (If a classmate could submit it, start again.)
- ☐ Does it show me doing or deciding something, not just feeling something?
- ☐ Does the reader learn something they could not get from my transcript?
- ☐ Is it about me, rather than about a person I admire?

WORTH KNOWING

- The topic matters far less than what you notice about it.
- Trauma is not required. Plenty of superb essays are about a job, a kitchen, or a bus route.
- Read it aloud. If you would not say it, do not write it.